



CIS 5640: Introduction to Game Design

Assignment 2: Analyzing Game Loops

For this assignment, you will analyze the core game loop of a complex game.

The goal is to understand how game loops work together to create an engaging player experience. By focusing on a game with **multiple interacting loops**, you will gain deeper insights into how design choices impact gameplay, player motivation, and overall satisfaction.

1. **Review MDA.** Before embarking on game loop analysis, review MDA by reading through two submissions from your classmates for Assignment 1 on discord. For each submission, leave one paragraph of feedback addressing the following questions:

- What was particularly insightful?
- Is there anywhere where you disagree with the MDA breakdown?
- How might the analysis be improved?

Choose submissions with the least feedback already posted – you will learn more from performing fresh analysis. Be thoughtful with your feedback. Leaving well-articulated feedback on game analysis is a core game designer skill.

2. **Play a game** that you know well. This game should be one with multiple interwoven game loops (e.g., resource management, combat, exploration). Choosing a game with a long playtime is a safe bet. Examples include Stardew Valley, The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild, Elden Ring, or Hades. Play at least 30 minutes of the game, using your previous knowledge of the game as well as your new understanding of game loops.
3. **Identify core game loops.** Describe at least two of these loops, focusing on:
 - At what time scale does the loop operate? Seconds? Minutes? Hours?
 - Clarity: What does the player need to do, and is it clear?
 - Motivation: What motivates the player to engage with this loop?
 - Feedback: How does the game provide feedback to the player?
 - Satisfaction: Why does engaging with this loop feel good?
4. **Analyze loop interactions.**
 - Draw a simple diagram (eg. pen+paper image, Miro, Obsidian Mindmaps) to visualize game loop dependency and interactions like we did in the lecture slides. You can start with following ideas:
 - Describe how the loops relate to each other in the game:

- i. How do they complement each other?
- ii. Is there a hierarchy (e.g., one loop feeds into another)?
- iii. Are there trade-offs or tensions created by balancing multiple loops?

5. **(Optional) Narrative Analysis:** Since we'll be exploring game narrative next week, we encourage you to analyze how these game loops contribute to the overall theme and narrative of the game. Don't worry if this feels all too unfamiliar—it's entirely optional, and you can decide whether or not to include this in your submission!